

Accelerator 3000, while the P965 Express needs you to add your own PCI-Express card.

Another design difference is that G965 Express can support 4 DIMMs per channel, so vendors can provide up to eight memory slots. In contrast, the P965 offers only two DIMMs per channel. Of course, this doesn't really say much, because most mainstream boards come with a maximum of four memory slots, and both chipsets support a maximum of 8 GB DDR2 RAM running at 800 MHz.

All the motherboards in this category have enough ports to take care of all your hard drive and optical drive requirements (SATA and IDE connectors). The Gigabyte GA-965P-DQ6 offers eight SATA ports—the highest in the category. Since both the chipsets have support for Intel's Matrix storage, all the boards have RAID support.

All the Gigabyte motherboards in this category—except for the GA-965GM-S2 had all solid capacitor designs, which translates to longer-lasting boards.

HD Audio was common across all the boards, with support for up to eight channels. Except for the MSI P965 Neo-F and Gigabyte GA-965GM-S2, all the boards feature optical out and S/PDIF out.

While all the boards offer Gigabit LAN, the ASUS P5B Deluxe WiFi-AP was the only board to feature an integrated Wi-Fi (802.11g) solution. Moreover, it doubles up as an access point, allowing you to create your own wireless network without having to buy a wireless router!

Both the GA-965P-DQ6 and the P5B Deluxe WiFi-AP use heatpipes. Gigabyte's heatpipe covers the Northbridge, Southbridge, and the CPU power MOSFET.

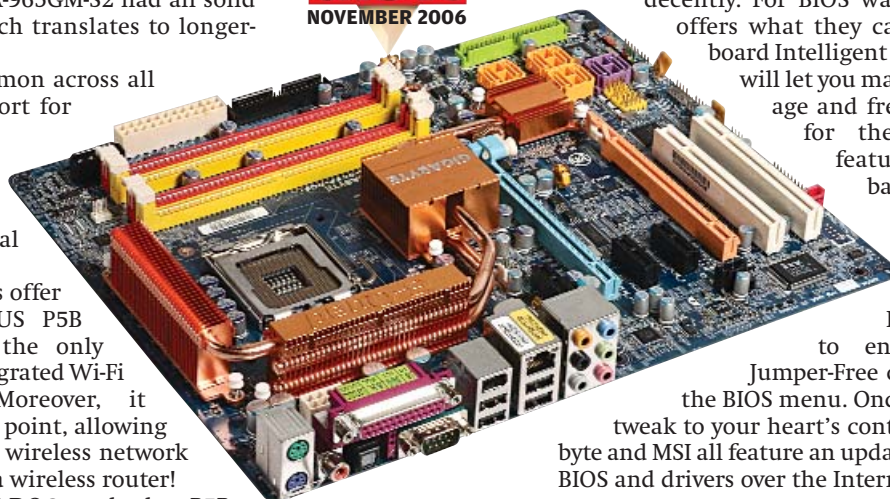
The layout of the Gigabyte GA-965P-DQ6 is very congested. If you own a 7900 GTX, you will

need to remove it to add or remove RAM. Another sore point is the lack of space between the CPU fan's heatsink and the heatpipe, making it a tricky affair when you remove the heatsink.

The ASUS P5B Deluxe WiFi-AP has identical problems. It adds one by placing the clear CMOS jumper too close to the graphics slot. The MSI P965 Neo-F has some layout issues as well: its 24-pin power connector arcs over the RAM, so you'll have to disconnect it to remove the RAM. As if that weren't bad enough, a big graphics card blocks the IDE connector! The Gigabyte GA-965G-DS3 is the best laid-out board here—all components are very easy to access.

Both Gigabyte and ASUS have incorporated some nifty overclocking features into their boards. If you prefer to soft-overclock (from within Windows), Gigabyte provides a utility called Easy Tune 5 that does the job decently. For BIOS warriors, Gigabyte offers what they call MIB (Motherboard Intelligent Tweaker), which will let you manipulate all voltage and frequency options for the board. ASUS features a Windows-based overclocking utility called AI Boost. To overclock using the BIOS, you need to enter the ASUS Jumper-Free configuration in the BIOS menu. Once there, you can tweak to your heart's content. ASUS, Gigabyte and MSI all feature an update service for the BIOS and drivers over the Internet.

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Gigabyte GA-965P-DQ6
Rock-solid performance

Performance Gaming

In the *Far Cry* test we ran, all P965 chipset motherboards gave us almost identical scores. The top two contenders—Gigabyte's GA-965P-DQ6 and ASUS' P5B Deluxe WiFi-AP—had almost same scores at a resolution of 1024x768. *Doom 3* is where the gap started to widen. While the Gigabyte GA-965P-DQ6 scored 165.1 fps, ASUS P5B Deluxe WiFi-AP managed 146.2 fps. This goes to indicate that the GA-965P-DQ6 has a better graphics subsystem.

Synthetic Benchmarks

Again, the P965 were quite close together. The Gigabyte GA-965P-DQ6 gave us a score of 11801, while the MSI P965 Neo-F managed 11770. Again, these scores indicate that the Gigabyte GA-965P-DQ6 is a better option for gamers.

In PCMark 2005, the MSI P965 Platinum raced ahead of the competition with an overall score of 7684. Its closest competitor was the MSI P965 Neo-F with 7544 points. The P5B Deluxe and GA-965P-DQ6 disappointed with scores of 7259 and 7499 respectively.

Gigabyte's GA-965P-DQ6 and GA-965P-DS3 returned almost identical memory scores in the SiSoft Sandra tests, leaving the competition far behind. In terms of CPU scores, all P965 chipset-based motherboards showed us that they were

PC Mark 2005 Performance (AMD)

